2026-03-01 — Customs and Tefillot of ליל שבת אנא בכח, כגוונא — , and במה מדליקין

Independent review · read fresh from the HTML alone, no transcript consulted · 1 March 2026 · 12 Adar 5786 · draft as it stood in final MM before the Sefaria step

1.Overall Read

A six-section write-up of roughly 3,000 words of body and a 14-note *Mareh Mekomos*. The thread is clear and well chosen: three small texts of Friday night, one for each of three movements, and a closing map of the siddur. The path: אנא בכח and the forty-two-letter Name (I); standing and bowing at לכה דודי (II); the night when Shabbos is also Yom Tov (III); the three reasons for במה מדליקין (IV); כגוונא, the Baal Shem Tov and the Piaseczner (V); and Chassidim and Misnagdim (VI).

The strengths are structure and voice; the weaknesses are four. (a) **The promise of the lead is larger than the delivery.** The lead claims the three texts were "inserted" by the Arizal's circle, the Baal Shem Tov's circle, and the Vilna Gaon's, but only the Baal Shem Tov and Gaon's circles are developed; the Arizal claim is asserted twice and never argued. (b) **Section VI contradicts itself** about where במה מדליקין sits (see Section 4). (c) **The notes are uneven**: some are specific and honest, others are padded generalities ("the passage is one of the most quoted in the Zohar"). (d) **Transliteration and Hebrew conventions are mixed** (Shabbos/שבת, kedushah/קדושה, Chassidic/חסידים).

2.What Works

- **The three-reasons structure of IV** is the best thing in the piece: the

headings ("The Latecomers," "A Reminder," "The Polemic Against the Karaites") are parallel, each reason is self-contained, and the callout on latecomers generalizes well.

- **The Karaite section** is vivid: the cold, dark Friday night, and the public recitation as a communal declaration.
- **The Closing "Living Map"** is a good idea: the siddur as a record of three movements.
- **The lead** is warm and explains the logic of the title.
- **The colophon and the dual-layer notes** follow the house format and the backrefs all resolve (14 refs, 14 notes).

3.Where It's Weak or Could Be Sharper

- **The "Why This Placement?" callout (I)** is the weakest paragraph: it asserts that the placement is "the Arizal's institution" and builds a number-symmetry (seven קולות, seven ברכות, seven verses, seven words) without a source, and the symmetry is inaccurate. A reader will not know whether this is the Rav's view, a traditional view, or the editor's.
- **II (standing and bowing)** is thin and its explanation of "left first" is odd: "a person facing forward has the Shechinah behind him" is unsupported and leaves the reader puzzled.
- **III (Yom Tov)** sets up two competing reasons but then "presses" on one without saying which is preferred; the final sentence ("subtler than the dramatic chol-to-kodesh shift") is the editor's inference, not the argument of any source.
- **The Anan paragraph (IV, Reason 3)** says "after being passed over for the position of Reish Galusa in favor of his uncle." The reader would like the date, the relationship, and a word on whether the historical record supports it; the note adds "responsa of Rav Sherira

Gaon and Rav Hai Gaon" with no specific reference.

- **V: the Piaseczner subsection** is a biography followed by a claim ("said after Kabbalas Shabbos but before Maariv, with deliberate joy, not whispered") that the note itself says needs to be verified. A statement that is flagged uncertain in a note should be hedged in the text.
- **The "ברוך הוא" subsection** describes a halachic problem and a solution, but nothing says where the problem arises (Is it a statement in the Shulchan Aruch?). A reader who does not know the principle will not follow.
- **VI is long on rhetoric and short on evidence**: the Gra's school "regarded [Kegavna] as illegitimate" and "worse, elevated the Zohar above the halachic siddur" is stated as fact; no source is given.

4.Factual / Citation Concerns

Concern 1 — Ana Becoach's structure. "Each of the seven verses opens with one of the seven words of the Name, and the initial letters of all forty-two of those words spell out the Name" is internally incoherent (seven words versus forty-two). The prayer has seven lines of six words, forty-two words; the initials of the words are the Name. Note 1 repeats the error ("each opening with one word of the seven-word Name").

Concern 2 — Kiddushin 71a. "בו נברא העולם" is presented as what the gemara says; the passage is about transmission of the Name to a modest and humble person who is in the middle of his years. Note 3 itself quotes the gemara without that phrase, so the body and note disagree. The notation " דף ע״א ע״א" repeats the letter alef.

Concern 3 — Shulchan Aruch "אורח חיים סימן רס״ב" and "תס״ח". Siman 262 is the siman of preparing the table, and Orach Chayim 668 (תס״ח)

concerns Shemini Atzeret, so neither covers standing at Lecha Dodi or Shabbos that falls on Yom Tov. These look like wrong simanim, and the "Rema's addition" of three steps is not a Rema known to this reviewer.

Concern 4 — The Tur and Beis Yosef both at "סימן ר״ע". The latecomers reason is credited to the Tur "in the name of the Geonim," the mnemonic reason to the Abudraham "and brought in the Tur," and the Karaite reason to the Beis Yosef "in the name of earlier sources." Three different reasons credited to the same siman by three different attributions is suspicious; it reads as though the attributions were assigned to fit the headings. Note 9 claims the Beis Yosef includes "the Geonic reason of the latecomers, the Abudraham's mnemonic reason, and a Karaite reason," a lot for one siman. A chronological problem as well: the Tur (died c. 1340) cannot easily have "brought" the Abudraham, who wrote around 1340.

Concern 5 — The mishnah's contents. The text says the closing mishnah of the perek deals with "עירובי תבשילין" and "the קביעות of one's meal"; the note says the closing mishnah is "שלושה דברים צריך אדם לומר," which are tithing, eruv and kindling the lights. The body and note disagree.

Concern 6 — Where is Bameh Madlikin? VI says "Sefardi-original placement: after Maariv"; "Misnagdic placement: between Kabbalas Shabbos and Maariv"; "Most Ashkenaz siddurim today print it exactly there"; and then the Living Map says "Bameh Madlikin at the very end (or not at all)." The reader cannot tell what the Sefardim, Chassidim and Ashkenazim each do.

Concern 7 — Dates and attributions. The Baal Shem Tov (1698–1760) and Danzig (1748–1820) are as commonly given; the Piaseczner (1889–1943) is fine. The note on the Baal Shem Tov cites "the Arizal's siddur as edited by the Baal Shem Tov's students" (anachronistic and confusing), and the "siddur of the Baal HaTanya" is a different, later work. "Whether… the prayer surfaces somewhat later in early kabbalistic circles" cites 12th–13th

century Provence/Spain, with no reference.

Concern 8 — Spelling of the name. The page title and header say "Rabbi Ephrati" while the folder and other files use "Efratti"; follow the house form consistently.

5.Small Polish Suggestions

1. Pick one form: "שבת" or "Shabbos"; "קדושה" or "kedushah"; avoid "Chassidic" beside "חסידים" in one sentence.
2. "hispayl" (a typo for *hispa'alus*) in the Piaseczner paragraph.
3. The "Rabbi Ephrati" kicker says "Sunday Morning שיעור on תפילה"; the shiur is on the Friday-night service, so name it.
4. The lead's "one was inserted by the Arizal's circle" should be dropped or supported.
5. Define "ראש גלות" (Exilarch) on first use; the English gloss is given only after.
6. "five-to-seven minute reading" and "approximately 5–7 minutes" in note 6 repeat; keep once.
7. Footnotes 2, 12 and 13 carry an *note-academic* block; keep these honest flags, but move the uncertainty into the body as a hedge.
8. The colophon should state the Sefaria check once the step is done.

6.Bottom Line

> *A well-organized, readable piece with a good spine, whose most memorable section (the three reasons for Bameh Madlikin) is also its strongest. The problems are in the details: the structure of Ana Becoach is stated incoherently, the Kiddushin source is mis-stated, two Shulchan*

> *Aruch simanim look wrong, three different reasons are credited to the same siman, the contents of the closing mishnah disagree between body and note, and Section VI is contradictory about who says Bameh Madlikin where. The piece also states several explanations (the Arizal's institution, the Gra's view, the Piaseczner's guidance) with more confidence than its own notes allow. Fix these, hedge the unsupported attributions, and add the missing background on Anan and the Chayei Adam, and the piece would stand as a sefer chapter.*

Produced by an independent editorial read of the HTML alone, without the transcript. Complement to the Shiur Review.